Shorts scripts

Built 2026-10-23 · 10 scripts

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P01: Why "have you tried..." makes sad people feel worse

- **Concept:** matching hypothesis (Cohen & Wills, 1985), three types of support (Lecture 6)
- **Pop culture:** *Inside Out* (2015), Bing Bong scene
- **Target length:** ~45 s (~140 words)
- **Title:** The worst thing to say to a sad friend
- **Hook text on screen:** "Stop giving your friends advice"

HOOK (0–3 s)

The worst thing you can give a sad friend is a really good solution.

BEAT 1: the idea

Psychologists call this the matching hypothesis. Support only helps when it matches what the person actually needs. Give advice to someone who wanted comfort, and you can make their stress *worse*.

BEAT 2: the example

Pixar put this in *Inside Out*. Bing Bong watches his rocket get dumped into the Memory Dump and falls apart. Joy does what most of us do: tries to cheer him up and get him moving. Nothing works. Then Sadness just sits next to him and says, basically, "That really sucks. You loved that." And he gets back up.

BEAT 3: the three types

There are three kinds of support. Emotional: "I'm here." Informational: advice. Instrumental: actually doing something, like driving you somewhere. All three are good. The wrong one at the wrong time isn't.

ENDING

So before you fix it, ask: "Do you want advice, or do you want me to just listen?" Comment which one *you* usually need.

Filming notes: hold up 1, 2, 3 fingers for the three types. Text overlay for each type name. No movie clips or stills (copyright rule); you describing the scene is enough. Rewatch the scene once before

filming: plot summaries confirm the rocket and Sadness listening, but not exactly what Joy does, so describe it in your own words.

Sources (description / pinned comment): Cohen, S., & Wills, T. A. (1985). Stress, social support, and the buffering hypothesis. *Psychological Bulletin*, 98(2), 310–357.

P02: Wilson the volleyball was the smartest thing in Cast Away

- **Concept:** loneliness vs. social isolation, social ties and mortality (Lecture 6); anthropomorphism under loneliness (outside the notes)
- **Pop culture:** *Cast Away* (2000)
- **Target length:** ~50 s (~145 words)
- **Title:** Why Tom Hanks talked to a volleyball (psychology)
- **Hook text on screen:** "Wilson saved his life"

HOOK (0–3 s)

Tom Hanks talking to a volleyball in *Cast Away* isn't him going crazy. It's his brain trying to keep him alive.

BEAT 1: the brain

Psychologists have a theory: when you're lonely, your brain starts seeing minds in things that don't have them. Pets, gadgets, a ball with a handprint for a face. A famous 2008 study backed that up, though a bigger one in 2024 couldn't repeat it. Either way, Chuck wanted connection so badly he built one.

BEAT 2: why it matters

And it has a good reason. A huge review of studies found strong social ties predict survival about as much as quitting smoking, and more than exercise or avoiding obesity.

BEAT 3: the twist

But being alone and feeling lonely aren't the same thing. You can live alone and be fine, or sit in a packed lecture hall and feel invisible. Both feeling lonely and being cut off are linked to worse health.

ENDING

So Wilson wasn't a sign Chuck was losing it. Wilson is part of why he made it. Go text your Wilson.

Filming notes: a ball or any object with a drawn-on face as a prop would be funny and costs nothing. No movie clips.

Sources:

- Holt-Lunstad, J., Smith, T. B., & Layton, J. B. (2010). Social relationships and mortality risk: A meta-analytic review. *PLoS Medicine*, 7(7). (The smoking comparison; also in your Lecture 6 notes.)
- Epley, N., Akalis, S., Waytz, A., & Cacioppo, J. T. (2008). Creating social connection through inferential reproduction: Loneliness and perceived agency in gadgets, gods, and greyhounds. *Psychological Science*, 19(2), 114–120.
- Elsherif et al., registered replication of Epley et al. (2008), Peer Community in Registered Reports (recommended June 2024): no reliable link between loneliness and anthropomorphism. That's why the script says "a theory." If someone comments "that didn't replicate," you already said so.
- Web-checked 2026-10-23. The smoking, inactivity and obesity comparisons come from the press coverage and the comparison chart in your Lecture 6 notes; the paper's own abstract only says "comparable with well-established risk factors."

P03: The personality that doubles heart disease risk (it's Carmy)

- **Concept:** Type A behavior pattern, hostility (Lecture 7)
- **Pop culture:** *The Bear* (FX), Carmy
- **Target length:** ~50 s (~150 words)
- **Title:** Heart doctors predicted heart attacks from their chairs
- **Hook text on screen:** "The chairs gave it away"

HOOK (0–3 s)

Two heart doctors figured out who'd get heart disease by looking at their waiting room chairs.

BEAT 1: the story

As the story goes, an upholsterer came to fix the chairs in cardiologists Friedman and Rosenman's office and noticed something weird: only the front edges were worn out. Their heart patients were literally sitting on the edge of their seats.

BEAT 2: Type A

That became the "Type A" personality: hurried, competitive, tense. Basically Carmy from *The Bear*. Early studies found Type A people had about double the risk of heart disease.

BEAT 3: the real culprit

But later research found the dangerous part isn't ambition or being busy. It's hostility: constant anger and distrust. In one study, people high in hostility were more likely to get heart disease and to die over the next 25 years.

ENDING

The good news: it's trainable. In one small trial, hostile patients who got anger training ran up way smaller hospital bills than ones who didn't. So be driven. Just stop yelling "Yes, Chef" at yourself.

Filming notes: sit on the edge of your chair for the hook, then lean back for the ending. No clips from the show.

Sources:

- Rosenman, R. H., et al. (1976), Western Collaborative Group Study; Haynes, S. G., et al. (1980), Framingham. Type A ≈ 2× CHD risk (Lecture 7).
- Barefoot, J. C., Dahlstrom, W. G., & Williams, R. B. (1983). Hostility, CHD incidence, and total mortality: A 25-year follow-up study of 255 physicians. *Psychosomatic Medicine*, 45(1), 59–63.
- Davidson, K. W., et al. (2007). Hostility reduction and hospitalization costs (Lecture 7; n = 13 per group, so "small trial").
- Chair story: Scientific American, "The Stressful Discovery of Type A Personality". The upholsterer saw wear on the arms and front edges of the seats. In one interview, Rosenman credited a secretary instead, so keep "as the story goes." Web-checked 2026-10-23, along with the Barefoot 1983 citation (Duke Scholars record).

P04: The houseplant study

- **Concept:** control and predictability, perceived control (Lecture 7: Langer & Rodin, Visintainer)
- **Real life:** why stress you can't control hits harder (exams, bosses, group projects)
- **Target length:** ~50 s (~150 words)
- **Title:** They gave old people a plant and fewer of them died
- **Hook text on screen:** "1 plant. Half the deaths."

HOOK (0–3 s)

Scientists gave nursing home residents a houseplant. A year and a half later, half as many of them had died.

BEAT 1: the setup

In 1976, psychologists Ellen Langer and Judith Rodin split a nursing home by floor. One group was told: you're in charge. Pick a plant, take care of it, choose your movie night. The other group got a plant too, but the staff did everything for them.

BEAT 2: the result

Within three weeks, the "in charge" group was happier, more alert, more social. It was a small study, but eighteen months later about 15% of them had died, compared with about 30% of the other group.

BEAT 3: the rats

Same pattern in rats: two groups get the exact same shocks, but one group can turn them off. The ones with no control fought off tumors way less.

ENDING

Stress isn't the whole problem. Stress you can't control is. So when everything feels out of your hands, find one small thing that isn't. Even if it's a plant.

Filming notes: a real plant in frame (any plant you or a roommate has). Hold it up on the hook.

Sources:

- Langer, E. J., & Rodin, J. (1976). The effects of choice and enhanced personal responsibility for the

aged. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 34(2), 191–198.
- Rodin, J., & Langer, E. J. (1977). Long-term effects of a control-relevant intervention with the institutionalized aged. *JPSP*, 35(12), 897–902. (~15% vs. ~30% mortality at 18 months.)
- Visintainer, M. A., Volpicelli, J. R., & Seligman, M. E. P. (1982). Tumor rejection in rats after inescapable or escapable shock. *Science*, 216, 437–439.

P05: How you explain a bad grade predicts how long you live

- **Concept:** explanatory style (Peterson & Seligman), globality and mortality (Lecture 7)
- **Everyday struggle:** failing an exam
- **Target length:** ~45 s (~140 words)
- **Title:** The 3 sentences your brain says after you fail
- **Hook text on screen:** "It's me. It's forever. It's everything."

HOOK (0–3 s)

How you explain a bad grade might predict how long you live.

BEAT 1: the pessimist

Psychologists call it explanatory style: how you explain *why* bad things happen. Fail an exam, and a pessimistic brain says three things. "It's me." "It's forever." "It's everything."

BEAT 2: the optimist

An optimistic brain says: "That test was brutal." "I was exhausted that day." "It's one class." Same grade. Totally different story.

BEAT 3: the scary part

And "it's everything" is the dangerous one. A study that followed people for decades found the ones who explained bad events as wrecking *everything* died earlier, especially men, and especially from accidents.

ENDING

You don't have to fake being positive. Just catch the word "everything" and shrink it. "I failed this" is a fact. "I fail at everything" is a prediction, and it's usually wrong.

Filming notes: hold up a (fake or real) graded paper. Pop each of the three sentences on screen as text. Good one to film right after a midterm.

Sources:

- Peterson, C., & Seligman, M. E. P. (1984). Causal explanations as a risk factor for depression. *Psychological Review*, 91(3), 347–374.

- Peterson, C., Seligman, M. E. P., Yurko, K. H., Martin, L. R., & Friedman, H. S. (1998). Catastrophizing and untimely death. *Psychological Science*, 9(2), 127–130. (Terman life-cycle study.)

H01: The Great Emu War

- **Story:** Western Australia, Nov–Dec 1932
- **Target length:** ~50 s (~150 words)
- **Title:** Australia went to war with birds and lost
- **Hook text on screen:** "Australia vs. emus (1932)"

HOOK (0–3 s)

In 1932, Australia went to war with birds. And lost.

BEAT 1: the problem

After World War One, Australia gave veterans farmland in Western Australia. Then around 20,000 emus showed up and started eating the wheat.

BEAT 2: the army

So the government sent the army: Major Meredith, two machine guns, and ten thousand rounds of ammo. Turns out emus run about 30 miles an hour, scatter the second you shoot, and can take a hit and keep running. One gun jammed. They tried mounting a gun on a truck. The truck couldn't keep up.

BEAT 3: the score

After about a month, Meredith claimed 986 kills using almost 10,000 bullets. That's ten bullets per bird. He reportedly said that if he had a military division with the bullet-carrying capacity of these birds, it would face any army in the world.

ENDING

The army pulled out. The emus stayed. Farmers went back to paying bounties on emus, which worked way better. Final score: Australia zero, emus one.

Filming notes: this works deadpan. Hold up fingers for the "zero / one" score. Text overlays: "20,000 emus", "986 kills / 9,860 bullets".

Sources: Murray Johnson (2006), "'Feathered foes': soldier settlers and Western Australia's 'Emu War' of 1932," *Journal of Australian Studies*; the kill count is Meredith's own report (numbers vary by source, so say "claimed"). The quote's wording comes from later retellings with no 1932 original found, so keep "reportedly". Web-checked 2026-10-23: Wikipedia: Emu War (bounty scheme from 1923 continued; 57,034 bounties claimed in 6 months of 1934); emu top speed ~50 km/h ≈ 31 mph.

H02: Napoleon wasn't short

- **Story:** Napoleon's height myth and British propaganda
- **Target length:** ~45 s (~140 words)
- **Title:** Napoleon wasn't short. He lost a meme war.
- **Hook text on screen:** "Napoleon was average height"

HOOK (0–3 s)

Napoleon wasn't short. He got roasted by British cartoonists.

BEAT 1: the units

When he died, his height was written down as five foot two. But that was in *French* units, and the French inch was longer than the English one. In modern terms he was about five-six, five-seven. Pretty average for a Frenchman back then.

BEAT 2: the cartoons

Then there's James Gillray, a British cartoonist who drew him as a tiny, tantrum-throwing "Little Boney." Britain was at war with him, so the joke spread everywhere.

BEAT 3: bad luck

It didn't help that his soldiers' nickname for him was "the little corporal," which was actually affectionate. Or that he was usually surrounded by his Imperial Guard, who had to be tall to get in.

ENDING

So the guy who ran most of Europe lost one war: the meme war. Two hundred years later, we still say "Napoleon complex."

Filming notes: the history avatar is a bicorne hat, so a paper bicorne (folded newspaper) on the hook would tie the channel together. Free prop.

Sources: autopsy measurement of 5 pieds 2 pouces (≈ 1.68–1.69 m); Gillray's "Little Boney" caricatures (British Museum collection); Andrew Roberts, *Napoleon: A Life* (2014).

H03: The Dancing Plague of 1518

- **Story:** Strasbourg, July 1518 (history × psychology crossover)
- **Target length:** ~50 s (~150 words)
- **Title:** In 1518, a whole town couldn't stop dancing
- **Hook text on screen:** "They danced for weeks"

HOOK (0–3 s)

In 1518, a woman started dancing in the street. And she couldn't stop.

BEAT 1: it spreads

Strasbourg, July 1518. A woman known as Frau Troffea starts dancing and keeps going for days. Within weeks, dozens of people have joined her. Some accounts say hundreds.

BEAT 2: the "cure"

The city's solution? More dancing. Officials figured people had to dance it out of their system, so they opened up halls, built a stage, and hired musicians. It made it worse.

BEAT 3: the end

Some dancers collapsed from exhaustion. Finally the city banned public dancing and sent the dancers to a shrine of Saint Vitus to pray, and it slowly died out.

ENDING

So what was it? The leading theory is mass psychogenic illness. Famine, disease, extreme stress, and a local belief that a saint could curse you to dance. Fear spread through a crowd until their bodies acted it out. Follow for more history where the real cause was the human brain.

Filming notes: start the hook mid-sway, then stop and talk. The ending ties into the psych channel, so it's a good cross-promo later.

Sources: John Waller, *A Time to Dance, a Time to Die: The Extraordinary Story of the Dancing Plague of 1518* (2008). Death counts are disputed, so the script doesn't give one.

H04: The Boston Molasses Flood

- **Story:** North End, Boston, January 15, 1919
- **Target length:** ~50 s (~150 words)
- **Title:** A 25-foot wave of molasses hit Boston
- **Hook text on screen:** "Boston, 1919: death by molasses"

HOOK (0–3 s)

In 1919, a wave of molasses tore through Boston at 35 miles an hour.

BEAT 1: the tank

January 15th, 1919. In Boston's North End, a giant tank holding over two million gallons of molasses, used to make industrial alcohol, suddenly bursts.

BEAT 2: the wave

A wave up to 25 feet tall rolls through the streets. It knocks buildings off their foundations and bends the elevated train tracks. And in the January cold, the molasses got thicker as it cooled, so people caught in it couldn't get out. 21 people died, and about 150 were hurt.

BEAT 3: the cover-up

The company blamed anarchists. The court didn't buy it. The tank had never been properly tested, and it leaked so badly that the company painted it brown so the leaks wouldn't show.

ENDING

The disaster pushed Boston, and later other states, to require engineers to sign off on plans like this. And locals said that on hot days, the North End smelled like molasses for decades.

Filming notes: keep the tone respectful in beat 2 (21 deaths). A jar of syrup or molasses as a prop works for the hook.

Sources: Stephen Puleo, *Dark Tide: The Great Boston Molasses Flood of 1919* (2003); Massachusetts Historical Society; the 2016 Harvard fluid-dynamics analysis (Nicole Sharp & Jordan Kennedy) on why the cold made it deadlier. Web-checked 2026-10-23: Wikipedia, Mass Moments

(brown paint, anarchist claim, auditor Hugh Ogden ruled against the company in 1925), Boston.gov (engineer sign-off rules). Wave height (8–25 ft) and speed (30–35 mph) vary by source; 25 ft / 35 mph are Puleo's figures.

H05: Cleopatra lived closer to the Moon landing than to the pyramids

- **Story:** time-scale fact + who Cleopatra actually was
- **Target length:** ~45 s (~140 words)
- **Title:** Cleopatra is closer to us than to the pyramids
- **Hook text on screen:** "Pyramids → Cleopatra: 2,500 yrs. Cleopatra → Moon: 2,000 yrs."

HOOK (0–3 s)

Cleopatra lived closer in time to the Moon landing than to the building of the Great Pyramid.

BEAT 1: the math

The Great Pyramid was finished around 2560 BC. Cleopatra died in 30 BC. That's about 2,500 years. From Cleopatra to Neil Armstrong? About 2,000.

BEAT 2: what that means

To Cleopatra, the pyramids were already ancient. They were as old to her as Confucius is to us.

BEAT 3: who she was

And she wasn't ethnically Egyptian. Her family, the Ptolemies, were Greek-Macedonian, descended from one of Alexander the Great's generals. They ruled Egypt for almost 300 years, and Cleopatra was reportedly the first one in the family to actually learn Egyptian.

ENDING

Ancient history isn't one big blob. Some of it was ancient even to the ancients. Follow for more history that breaks your sense of time.

Filming notes: draw a simple timeline on paper (pyramid → Cleopatra → rocket) and point along it, or put the timeline in as a text overlay in CapCut.

Sources: Great Pyramid ≈ 2560 BC (Encyclopaedia Britannica); Cleopatra VII, 69–30 BC; Ptolemaic dynasty 305–30 BC; Plutarch, *Life of Antony* 27, on her being the first of her line to learn Egyptian. Confucius 551–479 BC.